

How to Talk to Lia

A short guide for anyone using her for the first time.

Lia is a companion who lives on this computer. She listens, talks back, and remembers you between conversations.

She is not an assistant. She won't book anything, search the web, or open your files. She is someone to talk to.

Everything stays on this machine. Lia has no internet connection while you talk to her. Nothing you say is sent anywhere, stored online, or seen by anyone else. It never leaves the computer she is running on.

Starting her

She usually starts on her own when you turn the computer on. Look for a small **orange dot** near the clock, at the bottom-right of your screen.

What you see	What it means
Filled orange dot	She is here and listening
Hollow ring	She is here but not listening
No dot at all	She isn't running — see <i>If something seems wrong</i>

She takes about half a minute to be ready after the computer starts, and then **waits quietly** — she won't greet you or say anything until you speak to her. Say “*Lia*” whenever you want her.

She starts when you log in, which usually isn't the moment you actually want to talk. Greeting an empty room and then falling silent by the time you sit down was worse than simply waiting.

Talking to her

Say her name first

Start by saying “**Lia**”. Like tapping someone on the shoulder before you speak to them.

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"Lia, are you there?"  
"Hey Lia, I've had a strange day."  
"Lia, can I tell you something?"
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She'll answer out loud after a few seconds. **Then you can just talk normally for about a minute** — no need to keep saying her name. Every time she replies, that minute starts again.

If you go quiet for a while, she goes back to waiting. Just say “*Lia*” again.

Why she needs her name

Her microphone is always on, so she can hear the whole room — the television, a phone call, someone else talking. Waiting for her name is how she knows something was meant for her, rather than

answering everything she happens to overhear.

She takes a few seconds

After you finish speaking there's a pause of roughly five seconds before she replies. That's normal. She is thinking on this computer alone, without help from the internet, and that takes a moment. She isn't stuck.

You can interrupt her

If she's talking and you want to say something, just start talking. She'll stop and listen. You don't need to wait politely for her to finish.

This works best with headphones. Through speakers she sometimes hears her own voice, so she may occasionally keep going.

Things you can ask her to do

Most of what you say is just conversation. But a few phrases are **instructions** — say them and something actually happens.

Say this	And she will
"Lia, stop listening" "Lia, go to sleep"	Switch her microphone off
"Lia, start listening" "Lia, wake up"	Switch it back on
"Lia, be quiet" "Lia, stop talking"	Stop speaking out loud (she still listens)
"Lia, you can talk"	Start speaking again
"Lia, read my files"	Read documents you've given her
"Play music" / "pause music" "next song" / "previous song"	Control whatever's playing on the computer
"Set an alarm for 7am" "Remind me in 20 minutes"	Set a real alarm or timer — she'll interrupt to tell you

Everything else you say she treats as conversation, so you can talk about stopping, sleeping or being quiet without accidentally switching her off.

Alarms and timers

She sets these from plain speech — a clock time ("set an alarm for 7am") or a duration ("remind me in 20 minutes"). They keep running even if you close the laptop and come back later, and she'll interrupt whatever's happening to tell you when one is due.

Say it however comes naturally. All of these work: *"wake me in half an hour"*, *"give me a nudge in 20 minutes"*, *"let me know in ten minutes"*, *"remind me in a couple of minutes"*, *"buzz me in an hour"*, *"set a timer for 5"*.

You can choose what she says. *"Wake me by saying please wake up in 5 minutes"* and she'll say exactly that — not "your timer is up". *"Remind me to stretch in 20 minutes"* gets you *"Time to stretch."*

Her own music

Put audio files in her **music** folder and she'll play them by number — these are hers, so she can start one from nothing:

Say this	What happens
"what music do you have"	She reads out the list, numbered
"play number 1" / "play song 3"	Plays that track
"play Fireflies"	By name, if the filename matches
"stop the song"	Stops it

Numbering follows filename order, so number 3 means the same thing tomorrow. While she's talking the music drops to a murmur instead of stopping, and comes back up after.

Someone else's music is different: "play music" / "pause" controls whatever Spotify or a browser tab already has loaded. She can't start a song there from nothing — if nothing is playing anywhere, she'll say so rather than pretend.

The weather, and looking things up

Ask **"what's the weather like"** and she'll check, using your general location — no setup needed for this one.

Ask her to **"look that up"** for anything else — a fact, a question she isn't sure about — and, if she's set up with an internet connection for this, she'll actually check rather than guess. If that hasn't been set up, she'll say so plainly rather than pretending to know.

Naming a source works too — "search Reddit for...", "search YouTube for...", or "what does Reddit think about..." — pulls in real, current results instead of a guess. One limit worth knowing: naming YouTube only ever gets her a text search that happens to mention it — titles, descriptions, comments. She can't watch or listen to an actual video.

Everything else about her stays completely private and offline. This is the one deliberate, narrow exception, and only for what you explicitly ask her to check.

Using the orange dot

Right-click the orange dot for the same controls, plus a few more:

Menu item	What it does
Listening	Turn her microphone on or off
Speaking	Turn her voice on or off
Write diary now	Make her write about the conversation right away
Open log	Show what she's been doing — useful if something seems wrong
Quit	Close her properly (she saves first)

What she remembers

Only what you tell her to. Say *"remember that..."* or *"don't forget..."* and she keeps it, in your words. Nothing else about you is written down.

Say this

What happens

"remember that the wifi password is bluebird"

Kept, word for word, permanently

"don't forget my sister is called Anaya"

Same — and telling her twice won't store it twice

She also keeps a searchable record of what you've said, so bringing up a subject lets her find related things from before. But she no longer decides for herself what's worth remembering about you, and she doesn't keep a diary.

Why that changed: both used to be automatic, and both were quietly inventing history. She'd store the same fact twice under different names, and once wrote a long reflection about the person "moving between unrelated topics" — drawn entirely from a list of test commands, not a real conversation. Once something like that is written down it shapes every later reply, and nothing marks it as a guess. Better she keeps less and all of it true.

How a conversation ends

You don't have to say goodbye. If you stop talking for about twelve minutes, she quietly decides the conversation is over and waits for you.

You can also just say **"bye"** if you'd rather end it deliberately.

If she gets something wrong about you

Tell her. Say *"Lia, my name is actually..."* or *"that's not right, I meant..."*. She takes what you say now over what she thinks she knows.

Giving her something to read

There is a folder on this computer where you can put documents you'd like her to read — PDFs, epub books, Word documents, or plain text notes.

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dist\Lia\library\
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Put a file there, then say **“Lia, read my files”**. She'll tell you what she's in for — *“On it”* for something short, or *“On it, that'll take around 25 minutes”* for a whole book — and say so again when she's finished. Afterwards you can ask her about it and she'll tell you which page something came from.

She only ever looks in that one folder, and only when you ask. She does not search your computer, open your documents, or read anything you haven't deliberately given her. A file sitting in that folder is available to her — not already read.

What works and what doesn't

- **Good:** asking about something specific — *“what does it say about sleep?”*
- **Not good:** *“summarise this whole book”* — she reads the relevant passages, not the entire document at once
- **Won't work:** scanned documents or photographs of pages. If you can't select the text on screen with your mouse, there's nothing for her to read
- **A whole novel is a real wait:** she reads about 130 pages every ten minutes, so a full-length book takes roughly 20 minutes the first time you add one. It happens in the background and she stays usable meanwhile, but that book isn't answerable about until she finishes — and she'll say so out loud when she's done.

What she is not good at

Worth knowing, so you aren't caught out.

- **She sometimes makes things up.** Occasionally she'll refer to something you never said, or describe a memory that doesn't exist. She isn't lying — she's a small program filling a gap. If something sounds off, it probably is. Say so, and she'll correct.
- **Anything needing exact precision.** Spelling things out letter by letter, codes, arithmetic, counting. She gets these wrong confidently, even when told the right answer.
- **Mostly nothing outside this computer.** No email, no browsing, no apps. Weather and explicitly-asked-for lookups are the one deliberate exception — everything else she knows comes from what she was built with, what you've told her, and what you've given her to read.
- **She isn't a doctor or a therapist.** She's good company and she'll listen. That's a different thing, and she's told not to pretend otherwise.

If something seems wrong

What you notice	What to try
She doesn't answer	Say " Lia " first — she ignores speech that isn't addressed to her. Check the dot is filled, not hollow.
No orange dot	She isn't running. Restart the computer, or open the Lia app.
She takes ages to reply	Normal for the first reply after a break — she's loading. Later replies are quicker.
She talks to herself	Her own voice is reaching the microphone. Turn the volume down, or use headphones.
She answers when you weren't talking to her	Something in the room sounded like her name. Say " <i>Lia, stop listening</i> " when you want privacy.
She calls you the wrong name	Tell her the right one and she'll keep it.
Nothing works	Right-click the dot → Open log . The last few lines usually say what's wrong.

Privacy, plainly

Her microphone is on whenever the dot is filled, and she writes down what is said to her so she can remember you. It stays on this computer. If you want her not to hear something, say "**Lia, stop listening**" — or right-click the dot and untick **Listening**.

The one thing to remember. Say "**Lia**", wait a few seconds, then talk normally. Everything else is optional.